

9 Excel Mistakes That Make You Look Like a Beginner

Fix #4 and people will actually stop asking you for help

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MISTAKE #1

Using VLOOKUP in 2026

VLOOKUP breaks when you insert a column. Can't search left. Slows on large data. XLOOKUP does everything VLOOKUP does and more. If you're still teaching VLOOKUP, you're setting people up to unlearn.

MISTAKE #2

Merged Cells Everywhere

They look clean. They break every formula that touches them. Use 'Center Across Selection' instead. Same look. Zero headaches. Your SORT and FILTER will work again.

MISTAKE #3

Hardcoding Numbers Inside Formulas

=A2*0.08 means nothing to the next person. Put 0.08 in a labeled cell called TaxRate. Now =A2*TaxRate reads like English. The #1 cause of Excel errors in two major academic studies.

MISTAKE #4

Not Using Tables (the actual Excel Tables feature)

Most people use Excel as a grid. Tables turn your range into a structured object. Formulas auto-expand. Filters built in. References become readable. The single habit that separates spreadsheet maintainers from spreadsheet fighters.

MISTAKE #5

Whole-Column References Everywhere

=SUM(A:A) looks clean but forces Excel to evaluate a million cells.
Use defined ranges or Tables. Your file performance will thank you.

MISTAKE #6

No Backup Before Editing Someone Else's File

Ctrl+Shift+S -> save a copy with today's date BEFORE you touch anything. You will mess something up. Past-you should give future-you the gift of an undo button.

MISTAKE #7

Color-Coding With No Legend

Red, yellow, green cells - and no key explaining what they mean. The person who built it knows. Nobody else does. Either add a legend or stop the coding.

MISTAKE #8

Volatile Functions Everywhere

NOW(), TODAY(), OFFSET(), INDIRECT() recalculate on EVERY keystroke in your workbook. One of these in 10,000 cells = an unusable file. Use them sparingly.

MISTAKE #9

Sheet1, Sheet2, Sheet3

Name your sheets. INPUTS, CALCULATIONS, OUTPUTS, DASHBOARD. Anyone opening your file should understand its structure in 5 seconds. This is free.

Which one are you fixing first? Drop it below. And follow for more Excel content every week.